

은/는과 이/가: 언제 무엇을 쓸까요?

Korean has two small words that often come right after a noun: the topic particle 은/는 and the subject particle 이/가. This sheet shows how to pick the right shape after a consonant or a vowel. It also shows when to use 이/가 (question words, answers, 있어요/없어요/아파요) and when to use 은/는 (topics and contrast). It also covers three short forms learners often get wrong: 제가, 내가 and 누가.

WHAT THIS IS FOR



Learners can attach the right form of each particle after a final consonant or a vowel (책은/책이, 친구는/친구가). They can choose 이/가 for question words and their answers (누가 왔어요? — 민수가 왔어요) and with 있어요/없어요/아파요 (머리가 아파요), and choose 은/는 to introduce a topic or show contrast (저는 학생이에요; 고기는 먹어요, 생선은 안 먹어요). They can also fix three common form errors: *저가 → 제가, *나가 → 내가, *누구가 → 누가.

1 THE PATTERN

은 / 이 (after a final consonant) Use these when the noun ends in a consonant (받침), e.g. 책, 식당, 음식.	은 marks the topic (what you are talking about). 이 marks the subject (who or what does or is something).	이 식당은 음식이 맛있어요. The food at this restaurant is tasty.
는 / 가 (after a vowel) Use these when the noun ends in a vowel, e.g. 친구, 키, 커피.	These mean the same as 은 and 이. Only the shape changes.	제 친구는 키가 커요. My friend is tall.
이/가 with question words and their answers Use these with question words such as 누가, 뭐가 and 어디가, and with the noun that answers them.	The question word and its answer are new information, so they take 이/가, not 은/는. Note: 누구 + 가 = 누가.	뭐가 제일 맛있어요? — 김치찌개가 제일 맛있어요. What's the tastiest? — The kimchi stew is the tastiest.
이/가 with 있어요 / 없어요 / 아파요 Use these for the thing that exists or doesn't exist, or the body part that hurts.	"There is / there isn't X" or "my X hurts"	배가 아파요. 집에 약이 있어요? I have a stomachache. Do you have any medicine at home?
은/는 for the topic Use it to say what the sentence is about, often yourself or something you are describing.	"As for X..." It sets up the topic, and the rest of the sentence tells you about it.	저는 한국어를 공부해요. I study Korean.
은/는 for contrast Use it when you compare two things, e.g. one is true and the other is not.	"X is like this, (but) Y is like that."	오늘은 바빠요. 내일은 괜찮아요. I'm busy today, but tomorrow is fine.





2 WATCH OUT

저가 (X) → 제가 (O): When 저 (I, polite) takes 가, it changes to 제가.

나가 (X) → 내가 (O): When 나 (I, casual) takes 가, it changes to 내가.

누구가 (X) → 누가 (O): When 누구 (who) takes 가, it shortens to 누가.

책가 (X) → 책이 (O): 책 ends in a consonant, so it takes 이, not 가.

3 YOUR TURN



CHOOSE AND FIX PARTICLES

Fill in or choose the right particle, and rewrite each wrong sentence correctly.

- Fill in each blank with 은 or 는: 지하철____ 빨라요. 버스____ 느려요.
- Fill in each blank with 이 or 가: 어깨____ 아파요. 그런데 오늘은 시간____ 없어요.
- Fill in the blanks. The first blank asks "who": ____ 전화했어요? — 수진____ 전화했어요.
- Correct the mistake: 저가 창문을 닫을게요.
- Correct the mistake in B's line: A: 누가 설거지할 거야? B: 나가 할게.
- You are meeting someone for the first time. Choose the right words: 안녕하세요? (저는 / 제가)
마리아예요. 스페인 사람이예요.

✓ ANSWERS

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| 1) 지하철은, 버스는 | 4) 제가 창문을 닫을게요. |
| 2) 어깨가, 시간이 | 5) 내가 할게. |
| 3) 누가, 수진이 | 6) 저는 |

